

## ANALYTICAL REPORT

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# Not Grim, but Poor

*Credential, algorithm, and the jurisdictional erosion of Bangladeshi journalism*

**Final Project**

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***Primary data:** interview with Saqlain Rizve, Staff Feature Writer, The Business Standard, and Bangladesh Correspondent, The Diplomat (S. Rizve, personal communication, August 15, 2026).*

## The puzzle

The most striking thing Saqlain Rizve said in fifteen minutes was also the most casual. The future of journalism, he insisted, is not grim; its pay is. Asked whether artificial intelligence would end the profession, he brushed the worry aside ("AI is just an assistant, not a challenge"), then kept returning to one word for what actually troubles him: insecurity, and specifically financial insecurity. That inversion is the hinge of this report. In the wealthy democracies the public and scholarly panic about journalism is mostly epistemic, a worry about whether a discredited and disrupted press can still authorise truth (Carlson & Lewis, 2015; Ekström & Westlund, 2019). Rizve, reporting from Dhaka, is calm about that question and anxious about the economic one. What he fears losing is not journalism the truth-practice so much as the journalist, the paid worker.

I want to take that inversion seriously, because it is a sharper diagnosis than the Northern one, not a naive one. What is happening to journalism in Bangladesh reads less as a crisis of truth than as a crisis of jurisdiction in Andrew Abbott's sense: the erosion of a profession's defended monopoly over a domain of expert work (Abbott, 1988). That jurisdiction is being dissolved from two sides at once. One is the supply side, the question of who is admitted to the work and on what credential. The other is the demand side, the question of how audiences reach information and whether they still need a professional to get it. The first is an education problem. The second is an algorithm problem. Rizve, without the theoretical vocabulary, described both with real clarity. The two parts that follow take each in turn, and a closing synthesis argues that in the Global South they close together into a pincer the original theories never had to name.

## Part One — The Education Question: credentialing, boundary-work, and an unfinished professional project

Pressed on the rise of "byte-size" digital outlets, Rizve reached, without any prompting, for the language of the classroom. The problem with the new content creators, he said, is that they have "no licence, ethics, or formal education". It is worth pausing on how quickly a working reporter, defending his trade, grasped for the credential. He called them unqualified. This is Thomas Gieryn's (1983) boundary-work caught in the act: the rhetorical labour by which the members of an occupation draw and police the line between real practitioners and pretenders. In Abbott's (1988) terms it is a jurisdictional claim, an assertion that a body of abstract knowledge, certified by formal education, entitles its holders to a domain of work and shuts others out.

The difficulty is that the claim is being made in a country where the profession it defends never fully consolidated. The usual Western framing, "de-professionalisation," the loss of a status journalism once held securely (Örnebring, 2010), travels badly here. In Silvio Waisbord's (2013) global account, professionalism in journalism is not a settled attainment but a permanently contested project, and across much of the world an arrested one. It never acquired the licensing regimes, the enforced pay floors, the union density, or the distance from proprietors that anchored the twentieth-century Anglo-American model. Bangladesh fits that description. Its press sits close to what Hallin and Mancini (2004; 2012), extending their comparative framework beyond the West, call a clientelist configuration: media houses "owned by corporate conglomerates," in Rizve's words, whose commercial and political alliances set the invisible edges of what can be reported. Editorial independence, he conceded, is therefore "a matter of gatekeeping." One works freely "as long as it doesn't go against the house policy or get sensitive."

Seen this way, the credential Rizve invokes does paradoxical work. Pierre Bourdieu (1986) taught us to read an educational qualification as institutionalised cultural capital, a certificate whose value lies in how readily it converts into economic and social standing. The bite-size creators expose an uncomfortable fact: in Bangladesh's news market that conversion has already broken down. If a contributor with "no formal education" can command the same audience, and sometimes the same income, as a salaried reporter, the credential no longer converts. And there

is a familiar sociological pattern here. Credentialism tends to grow loudest as an ideological defence at exactly the moment it is weakest as an economic reality. The louder the boundary-work, the more the boundary is failing to pay. Rizve's confidence that the amateurs "will go down since they don't have an authentic pool of their own work" is better read not as a forecast but as professional ideology in Mark Deuze's (2005) sense: one of the shared, self-legitimizing beliefs about autonomy and public service through which journalists narrate their own indispensability, and through which an "interpretive community" holds together under threat (Zelizer, 1993).

For a reader outside Bangladesh, the point worth drawing out is this. The material scaffolding that would make the credential mean something economically does exist in Bangladesh, but only on paper. The state's instrument for underwriting journalistic professionalism is the Wage Board, a statutory pay scale revised every few years. Rizve named its non-implementation as the single reform that matters most: "the salary scale... so that anyone can't be removed from the job at any time." Yet the Wage Board is contested from both ends. Proprietors' bodies have called successive awards unrealistic, while journalists' unions demand a new one (Bangladesh Sangbad Sangstha, 2026), and enforcement is thin either way. Umama Rafid's (2026) reporting from a single upazila found that of sixty to seventy working journalists, "only two or three receive any form of regular monthly honorarium," the rest holding "no appointment letters, no contracts, and no coverage under the national wage board." That is what arrested professionalisation actually looks like: a profession whose credential is invoked at the boundary while its wage floor was never laid. Harry Braverman's (1974) account of proletarianisation, the stripping of autonomy and security from ostensibly skilled work, fits the outcome closely. Rizve's own warning that unpaid local reporters end up using "the press card" for extortion is proletarianisation at its most corrosive: the credential surviving as an instrument of rent-seeking once the wage behind it has gone.

So the education lens yields a first thesis. The threat the bite-size outlets pose is not that they will out-report the professionals. It is that they show, publicly and daily, that the professional credential has gone economically hollow in a market that never funded it properly. The boundary-work grows more strident as the boundary loses its cash value.

## Part Two — The Algorithm Question: platformisation and the unbundling of journalistic authority

Rizve's second preoccupation was the "byte-size" outlets themselves, and here his instinct, though sharp, pointed at the wrong culprit. He dismissed AI as a mere "assistant," and he was right to. The fear that generative models will author the news and replace the reporter at the keyboard is what Matt Carlson (2015) analysed as a recurring panic over automation and journalistic authority, a panic organised around the wrong axis. The disruption Rizve actually described has nothing to do with who writes the copy. It has to do with who distributes it. The bite-size houses, he noted, have no reporters and no editors; they "just use the news of other big media houses on their social media." He called them parasitic. What he was describing, without the term for it, is platformisation (van Dijck, Poell & de Waal, 2018): the reorganisation of the whole news ecology around the distributive and economic logic of a few social platforms.

The classical model of journalistic power was gatekeeping, the profession's control over the scarce channel between an event and its audience (Shoemaker & Vos, 2009). The platform dissolves that gate. Once the feed rather than the front page is where audiences meet information, the algorithm becomes the gatekeeper, and its criteria are engagement and retention rather than significance or verification (Gillespie, 2014; Bucher, 2018). Tarleton Gillespie's (2014) argument that algorithms do not simply sort public knowledge but help constitute it, deciding what counts as "relevant" and so what counts as real, is the mechanism behind Rizve's most anxious observation: that unregistered outlets "present on social media" have left people "confused about which is true and which is false," with mis- and disinformation "spread both knowingly and unknowingly." That is close to a textbook account of information disorder (Wardle & Derakhshan, 2017). Its engine is not the amateur's dishonesty but the platform's indifference, a recommender system that rewards the shareable over the true and routes attention through what Thorson and Wells (2016) call curated flows that no newsroom controls.

The deeper structural move, and the contribution the interview makes possible, is what I will call the unbundling of journalism. A newspaper historically bundled three separable things: the expensive apparatus of newsgathering, a distribution channel, and an audience's attention, which advertisers paid to reach. Professional journalism was viable because the bundle could not be

split. To reach the audience you had to pass through the newsroom. Platforms split it apart. The bite-size outlet takes the platform's distribution and its aggregated attention while pushing the costly first component, the reporting, back onto the professional houses whose stories it reposts. James Webster's (2014) work on the fragmented "marketplace of attention" explains why this is fatal rather than merely irritating. Attention now flows to whoever wins the feed, and the winner need not have paid for a single reporter. Nielsen and Ganter (2018; 2022) document this asymmetry of dependence between publishers and platforms in the North; Rizve's testimony extends it to a market where publishers have even less leverage. The professional newsroom becomes an unpaid wholesaler to platform-native retailers.

This reframes Rizve's confidence and his fear at once. He is right that the amateurs produce no "authentic pool of their own work," but wrong to conclude they will therefore "go down." Under platform logic they need no such pool. Their business model is the arbitrage of distribution, not the production of knowledge. This is also why his optimism about knowledge ("AI just helps people explore more") sits so comfortably beside his economic dread. The algorithm does not threaten journalism's ability to know things. It threatens journalism's ability to be paid for knowing them, by cutting the historic link between the cost of newsgathering and the revenue from attention. The epistemology survives. The business model does not.

## **Synthesis — The Pincer: a political economy of double dispossession**

The two lenses are not parallel. They close like a pincer, and the particular tragedy of the Bangladeshi case is that they close on a profession with no floor beneath it.

Consider the sequence. In the twentieth-century North, professional journalism was funded by advertising rents and cushioned by relatively strong labour institutions. When platforms began to pull the advertising rent away, the profession still had the residue of a wage structure and union protection to fall back on, however eroded. Bangladesh reaches the platform moment before that scaffolding was ever finished. The Wage Board, the state's mechanism for a professional pay floor, is unenforced and politically contested (Bangladesh Sangbad Sangstha, 2026; Rafid, 2026), and ownership is clientelist rather than independently commercial (Hallin & Mancini, 2012). So the algorithmic loss of advertising attention traced in Part Two lands on a workforce that the

failure of professionalisation traced in Part One had already left without security. I would call this a double dispossession. The credential was never made to pay, and now the distribution channel that might have funded it has been captured. Two clocks running at different speeds, the North's slow de-professionalisation and the South's never-completed professionalisation, strike the platform hour together, and the Southern journalist takes the collision in his own income.

Read against the data, Rizve's own diagnosis confirms the political economy rather than the epistemics. He notes, correctly, that overt political and legal pressure has eased: "now in 2026 there is little political and legal pressure." The record supports him. The repressive Digital Security Act, under which more than 7,000 cases were filed between 2018 and its repeal (Committee to Protect Journalists, 2023), was replaced by a Cyber Security Act that rights groups judged to have kept most of its coercive architecture (Amnesty International, 2024). Even so, after the 2024 transition the acute climate improved, and Bangladesh's place on the World Press Freedom Index rose from 165th of 180 in 2024, its lowest to that point, to 149th in 2025 (Reporters Without Borders, 2026). If the story were mainly about the state repressing truth, that is a recovery. But the thing Rizve fears did not improve, because it was never really political. Impunity persists; the investigation report in the Sagar–Runi murders has now been deferred more than a hundred times, most recently for the 128th (The Business Standard, 2026), and six journalists were killed in the 2024 uprising with justice still elusive (Reporters Without Borders, 2025). The chronic condition, the one that will still be there when the next government has come and gone, is economic. The danger to Bangladeshi journalism is not that the state will silence it. It is that the market will not pay for it.

This leads to the report's central claim: most of the literature is trying to save the wrong object. The Northern debate works to protect journalism, meaning the epistemic function, the authorisation of public truth. Rizve's testimony suggests that in the Global South the endangered thing is narrower and more human. It is the journalist: the paid, secure, credentialed worker. The two call for different remedies. Epistemic anxiety points toward fact-checking, media literacy, and platform regulation. The economic crisis Rizve describes points toward labour policy, meaning enforced wage boards, contracts, appointment letters, and portable protections. That is the unglamorous infrastructure of a profession, and it is exactly what the fascination with AI and misinformation keeps pushing out of the policy conversation.

## **A counter-reading**

Honesty requires stating the strongest case against this argument, because a fair reader will raise it. The optimistic reading holds that credential erosion is really democratisation. The collapse of the professional boundary lets in voices that were kept out, rural, poor, non-elite, and platform distribution gives underfunded Southern journalism a reach it could never previously afford. On this view the bite-size outlet is not a parasite but a sign of a healthy widening of who gets to speak, and the participatory turn is emancipatory rather than corrosive (Carlson & Lewis, 2015; Örnebring, 2010). There is force in this. A press that was clientelist, elite and Dhaka-centric is no golden age worth mourning, and the professional boundary was always also a mechanism of exclusion.

The rejoinder is that the democratisation of voice and the destruction of livelihood are not the same event, and the platform delivers the first while speeding up the second. Wider participation is a real gain. But it does not follow that the costly, verified, adversarial reporting Rizve values can come from contributors who, by his account and Rafid's (2026), cannot earn a living from it. A media ecology can grow more inclusive and less able to fund original investigation at the same time. So the task is not to rebuild the old boundary but to attach a wage to the new and wider practice, which brings us back to the labour argument rather than away from it.

## **Limitations**

This analysis rests on a single fifteen-minute interview, and its author belongs to the community under study, a position that gives interpretive access but also carries the risk of reproducing the very professional ideology the report takes apart. Rizve is also an internationally connected, salaried, Dhaka-based writer, and the local reporters whose precarity anchors the argument appear here only through his account and secondary reporting. A fuller study would need practitioners from both sides of the metropolitan and rural divide and the salaried and freelance divide, would pair the interview with newsroom economic records, and would test the unbundling claim against the kind of audience-flow data platform research now makes available. The claims here are offered as disciplined hypotheses drawn from one rich case, not as settled findings.

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